managed to extricate its diplomats and other citizens, but after decades of backing anti-Taliban forces, New Delhi found that its long-time adversary was now in complete control of the country.

India had been excluded from negotiations in the lead up to the US withdrawal. The United States needed Pakistan to bring the Taliban to the negotiating table and sidelined New Delhi. Russia also excluded or downplayed India's role in a parallel Moscow process. Yet while India initially appeared to be among countries most adversely affected by the Taliban's return, New Delhi soon engineered direct negotiations with the new leaders in Kabul. The return of tensions between Afghanistan and Pakistan may have helped. Without initially offering recognition to the Taliban government, India re-established a diplomatic mission in Kabul, provided grains and humanitarian relief, and continued its technical assistance as part of prior aid projects. At the same time, security concerns prevented India from reissuing visas to Afghans, including many students who had been attending institutions of higher education.

As with India's west, turmoil erupted to India's east in Myanmar following a coup by military leader Min Aung Hlaing against the elected government of Aung San Suu Kyi in 2021. For India, this revived memories of the late 1980s and early 1990s, when India initially backed the civilian leadership in that country. Instead, India initially attempted to not engage politically with the Myanmar junta, so as to avoid lending credence to the coup d'état, while continuing bureaucratic and military-to-military engagement. This was motivated by a few factors including continuing Indian assistance projects and vaccine aid, managing the long land border, and stemming infiltration and the spread of the Covid-19 pandemic. Another implicit consideration was not ceding space to China, which had long benefited from Myanmar's international isolation. India's provision of a second-hand Russian submarine to Myanmar represented a new form of engagement with the country.

A crisis—in this case an economic one—also broke out in Sri Lanka, where debt levels proved unsustainable following a decline in tourism as a result of the pandemic. Although Sri Lanka had earlier turned to China for